

NM facing sudden death vs. Miners

By PAT PENCE
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Bob Leigh sat quietly in the lounge in Tucson nearly a month ago.

He slowly twirled his finger around the rim of his glass. His mood was bright but pensive.

THE LOBOS HAD just swept three straight from mighty Arizona on the Wildcats' own baseball diamond.

"This thing is not over yet," Leigh interjected when reminded that his club, with a 4-2 record at the time, probably would be favored in the Western Athletic Conference Southern Division.

And, favored they were, until dropping five of six games against Arizona State and Texas-El Paso. That span included a 3-game sweep by UTEP in El Paso two weeks ago.

"The team that beats UTEP will win this thing. The team that can't beat them is gonna have all kinds of problems," Leigh said way back when. . . .

AND, AT NO OTHER time, was that statement more prophetic than now.

The Lobos open a do-or-die 3-game series against UTEP tonight at the Sports Stadium (7:30).

The Wolfpack, now 7-8 in WAC play, still can tie for the title, but must sweep all three games from the Miners. The series concludes with a 1 p.m. double header tomorrow at Lobo Field.

Even a sweep won't assure New Mexico of a tie. Arizona State leads with a 9-6 mark while Arizona is 8-7. ASU plays at Arizona this weekend and two victories clinches the title.

HOWEVER, SHOULD Arizona win two of three while the Lobos are sweeping three, the league chase would end up in a 3-way tie. On the other hand, should Arizona sweep ASU, then the Wildcats would take the league crown.

Leigh will start ace lefty Jim Kremmel on the mound tonight in an effort to stop the hard-hitting Miners. UTEP, perhaps not endowed with the finest pitchers in the WAC, is as good a hitting

team as the Wolfpack will face or have faced all season.

The most consistent offensive star for the Miners this season has been Bob Prokopowicz — a name familiar with Albuquerque baseball fans.

Prokopowicz was a starting outfielder for the University of Albuquerque before that institution dropped intercollegiate athletics after the 1969 campaign. The big left-handed hitter went 6-for-11 two weeks ago against UNM.

LEIGH WILL COME back with Gary Jacobs (7-3) and Dan Ketcherside (2-4) in tomorrow's twin bill finale.

Miner Coach Andy Cohen will start ace Marc Bombard (7-5) tonight — which is organized baseball night. All organized youth baseballers — excluding public school participants — will be admitted free tonight if they appear at the gate in uniform and either with their coach or a paying adult.

The mound opponents for Jacobs are Ketcherside tomorrow probably will be Harry Milner (7-6) and Jim Greggerson (8-3).

Kremmel will be trying for the third time to beat the Miners this season. Few opponents have been able to touch the junior lefty who has sparked throughout the season — except UTEP.

KREMSEL IS 9-4, but 0-2 against Texas-El Paso. The Miners edged him in the Wolfpack's season-opening game, 6-5.

Then, two weeks ago, the Columbia, Ill., southpaw was bombed for six runs and 10 hits in seven innings.

It almost appears that the fabled "no-hit jinx" has hit the 6-foot, 180-pound hurler. Not since his WAC-history-making no-hitter against Arizona a month ago has Kremmel pitched to his potential.

He may have to tonight. There is no tomorrow. The Wolfpack literally cannot afford to lose one game in the 3-game set.

As Leigh said, "the team that can't beat them is gonna have all kinds of problems."